From Clauses to Sentences

Marc Alexander · Week 4

1. Identifying clause elements

(Predicators, Subjects, Objects, Complements, Adverbials)

Tam regards me sardonically for a moment as I slam the door, but remains a very quiet fellow. I am becoming very hungry. Richie is providing the food from the plastic lunch box, and he gives me a sandwich. He swigs the Irn Bru and hands it to Tam.

2. What's left?!

Conjunctions!

3. Where Are We?

- Last week, we looked at how clauses contain phrases, and how those phrases have a *function* within a clause (Subject, Predicator, Object, Complement, Adverbial)
- Recap:
  - Phrase structure is about the *internal* structure of phrases (eg inside a NP, what functions as modifier, headword or neither?)
  - Clause structure is about how phrases *combine* in larger structures, such as sentences (eg is the NP functioning as the Subject or the Object of a clause?)

4. The Levels of Grammar *(The 'Rank Scale')*

- **Sentence:** Made up of main *clause(s)* plus possible subordinate *clause(s)*
- **Clause:** Made up of *phrases* acting as Subject/Predicator/Object/Complement/Adverbial
- **Phrase:** Made up of *words* acting as headwords or modifiers in a Noun Phrase/Verb Phrase/Prepositional Phrase/Adverb Phrase/etc.
- **Word:** Noun/Verb/Adjective/Preposition, etc.

5. Okay, what is a clause?

- The key characteristic of a clause is that it *must* contain a VP functioning as Predicator
- We can think of clauses as being built up around Predicators; a clause is essentially a Predicator with its associated (optional) SOCA elements
  - Often, but by no means always, the basic structure is SPOC with As cropping up anywhere in between
- And the main thing about clauses is that they are the elements which make up a *sentence*

6. How do clauses make sentences?

- Firstly, **simple sentences** are those which consist of one clause (ie, one Predicator)

> He awoke in the night.
> I love grammar.
> Why do you hate me?
> She really should go to the shops today.
> The wolves will never stop hunting me.

- But not all sentences are simple; some contain more than one clause
- These are **compound** sentences and **complex** sentences
  - Compound sentences involve coordinating clauses together
  - Complex sentences involve clauses which are embedded inside other clauses

7. Complex vs Compound

- Compound sentences use the **coordinating conjunctions** *and, or, but*, or *nor*
- Complex sentences have **main clauses** and **subordinate clauses**
  - Main clauses could be simple sentences, or parts of compound sentences
  - Subordinate clauses are embedded in a main clause, and can't stand on their own
  - They use subordinating conjunctions, such as *after, although, as, because, before, if, how, however, like, once, since, than, that, though, till, unless, until, when, where, while,* etc.
  - Subordinate clauses do the job of a clause element – that is, a subordinate clause can be a Subject, Object, Complement or Adverbial within a main clause – and some can work as modifiers inside a phrase

> He **awoke** in the night and **discovered** he **loved** grammar.
> I **loved** grammar when I first **read** about it.
> I **love** grammar but I don't **love** my wife.
> What you**'re saying** about grammar **is** awesome.
> You **can kick** my dog, you **can insult** my family, you **can steal** my wine, but you **can't insult** grammar in my house.
>
> Note the commas: coordinating conjunctions can be left out altogether (Leech calls this *unlinked coordination*). The commas here are doing the same job as *and*.
>
> After we **learn** grammar, we **can take on** the world.
> It **would be** a shame if sex and rock music **distracted** us from grammar.

8. Decision Process

1. Count the Predicators
   - One Predicator? One clause: simple sentence
   - More than one Predicator? Look for *and, or, but, nor* (and for commas doing the same job as *and, or, but, nor*)
2. Check what the conjunction actually joins – words and phrases can be coordinated too
3. Test each clause on its own
   - If every one could stand alone: compound sentence
   - If **any one** cannot: it is subordinate and the sentence is complex

9. Sentences and Clauses

- Simple sentence
  - One Predicator, one clause (must by definition be a main clause)
  - Bill is happy. He loves grammar. Luckily, he easily found similar friends.
- Compound sentence
  - Two+ Predicators, two+ main clauses, coordinating cj(s) (*and, or, but, nor*)
  - Bill is a grammarian and loves his job. He does grammar all day, but also has other interests like phonetics.
- Complex sentence
  - Two+ Predicators, one+ main clause(s), one+ subordinate clause(s) which act as SOCA, subordinating cj(s) (*because, although, unless, if, when, whilst, whether,* etc)
  - If a sentence contains both coordination and a subordinate clause, it is complex. A subordinate clause anywhere makes the whole sentence complex.
  - Because grammar makes him happy, Bill is content. He is never happier than he is when parsing sentences.

10. Recognising Subordinate Clauses

- What if there is no subordinating conjunction?
- Look for non-finite verbs (see UGiST) such as *to go, going, having gone,* etc:
  - **Going to** the shops, I realised I had lost my puppy.
  - **To be** honest, I thought he was right next to me.
  - **Having lost** my puppy in Waitrose, I cried like a baby.
  - I was delighted **to see** my puppy again.
- Look for a wh- element (*who, whom, whose, what, which, when, where, how*) at the start of the clause:
  - **What you're saying about grammar** is awesome.
  - I know **which book you mean.**
  - The student **who sat at the front** asked a good question.
- Subordinate clauses can be replaced by phrases which carry out the same clause function:

> I told her about my lost puppy.
> I told her the story.
> I told her something.
> Going to the shops, I realised I had lost my puppy.
> That day, I realised I had lost my puppy.
> To be honest, I thought he was right next to me.
> Genuinely, I thought he was right next to me.
> Having lost my puppy in Waitrose, I cried like a baby.
> All day I cried like a baby.
> I was delighted to see my puppy again.
> I was delighted by it.

11. Some Sentences


THE SCREEN IN REVIEW

FIGURE 1 A newspaper clipping of the film-review column The Screen in Review, with a photograph of a man in evening dress

> Ten persons are isolated in a house on an island off the English coast. Out of this lethal hocus-pocus, René Clair has produced an exciting film and has directed a splendid cast in it with humor and a light macabre touch.
> While the score is quaintly tallied on a china centerpiece, the victims are clipped off like clockwork.

12. Labelling Clauses

- Phrases get surrounded by round brackets (), clauses by square brackets [], sentences by squiggly brackets {}
- Main clause = MCl, subordinate clause = SCl
  - There are names for the subtypes of subordinate clause - see *UGiST*
- Coordinating conjunctions sit outside of clauses and phrases
- Subordinating conjunctions sit outside of phrases but inside the subordinate clause
- Sentence = Se

13. Example 1

	S	M	H	P	H	O	M	H	A	H	
MCl[	(His	family)		(bought)		(a	house)		(there.)		]
	NP	d	N	VP	V	NP	d	N	AvP	Av	

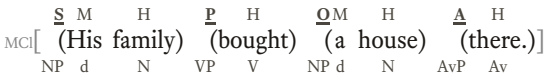
14. Step 2: Label headwords and modifiers

	S	M	H	P	H	O	M	H	A	H	
MCl[	(His	family)		(bought)		(a	house)		(there.)		]
	NP	d	N	VP	V	NP	d	N	AvP	Av	

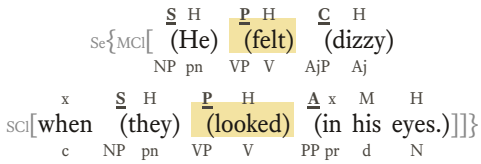
15. Step 4: Label the phrases for form

	S	M	H	P	H	O	M	H	A	H	
MCl[	(His	family)		(bought)		(a	house)		(there.)		]
	NP	d	N	VP	V	NP	d	N	AvP	Av	

16. Step 6: Label the clause



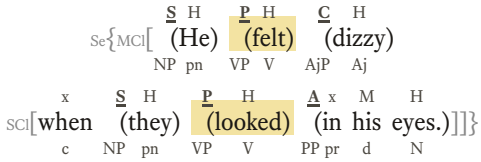
17. Example 2



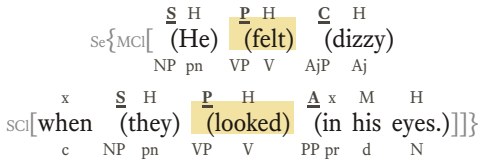
18. Step 1: Label the words

Look out for conjunctions!

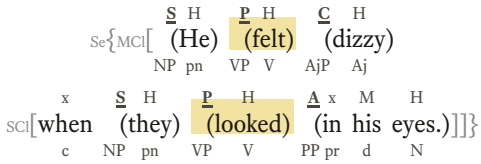
19. Step 2: Label the phrases for form



20. Step 4: Count the Predicators!



21. Step 6: Label the clauses



Remember: subclauses go inside the main clause.

22. Simple and complex grammatical styles

Donald Barthelme: 'Edward and Pia'

Edward looked at his red beard in the tableknife. Then Edward and Pia went to Sweden, to the farm. In the mailbox, Pia found a check for Willie from the government of Sweden. It was for twenty-three hundred crowns **and** had a rained-on look. Pia put the check in the pocket of her brown coat. Pia was pregnant. In London she had been sick every day.

Eight Predicators, therefore eight clauses
In six simple sentences and one compound sentence

Henry James, *Washington Square*

He was a thoroughly honest man – honest in a degree **of which** he had perhaps lacked the opportunity to give the complete measure; **and** putting aside the great good nature of the circle **in which** he practised, **which** was rather fond of boasting **that** it possessed the 'brightest' doctor in the county, he daily justified his claim to the talents attributed to him by the popular voice.

Ten Predicators, therefore ten clauses
In one complex sentence

- Different grammatical styles (simple and complex):
  - have different processing demands
  - have a different degree of formality
  - are associated with speech (simple) and writing (complex)
  - signal clause relationships differently

23. The Levels of Grammar *(The 'Rank Scale')*

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24. So what's left?

- Next week – the penultimate grammar lecture!
- What happens when the rank scale doesn't behave entirely normally…?
- *Rank-shift* (*subordination* and *embedding*), as well as another look at *substitution*, *ellipsis*, *particles*, and *phrasal verbs*.

25. Follow-up

- You should now:
  - be up to Chapter 8 of *Understanding Grammar*, and again make sure to try the self-assessment Activities at the end of the chapters (answers at the back of the book).
  - have completed all the Units and the corresponding Exercises of the *English Grammar* site.
- If you have questions, talk to your tutor or do please come see me (details on Moodle)